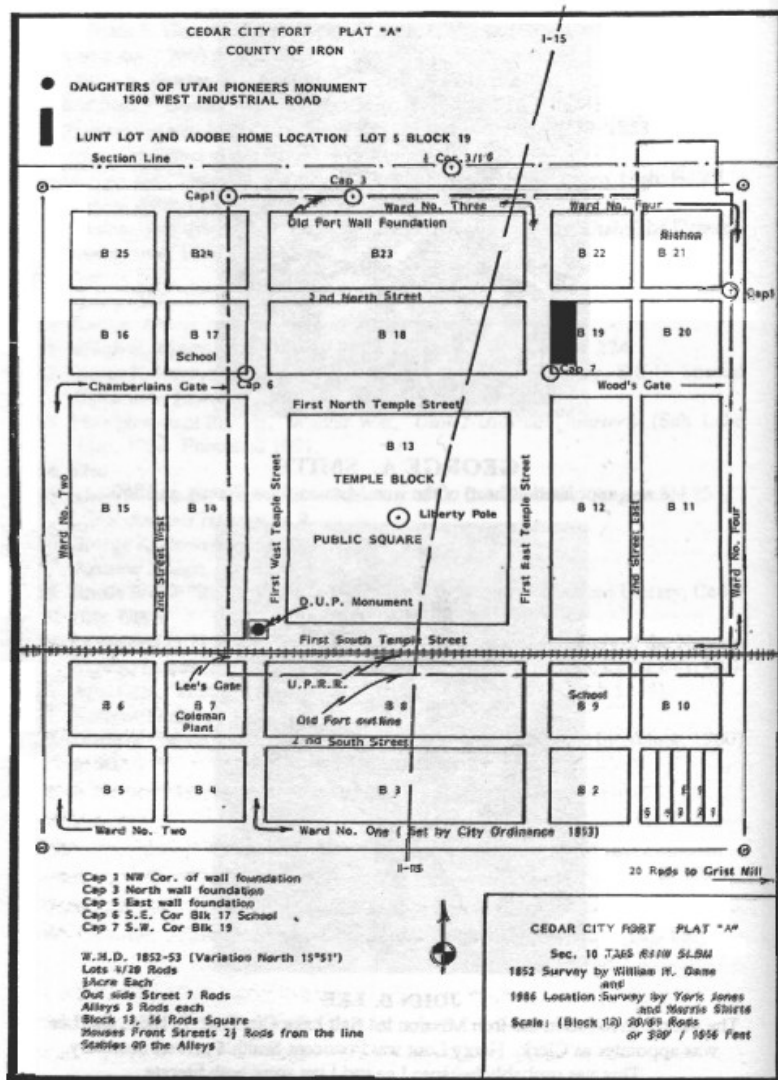


CHAPTER XI

BUILDING A NEW FORT 1853

Approximately fifty more families moved to Cedar City the fall of 1853, making it necessary to enlarge the farming lands to provide area for them to grow crops. These new people were called to strengthen the settlement and fortify the work force at the Iron Works. A large field was surveyed and fenced in the spring for the planting of grain to accommodate this influx. A "call" was given to these families to build up the settlement, not only to help on the Iron Works, but to replace the people who had left for California. Cedar City residents had tried to comply with the requests from Brigham Young and had worked diligently to finish the new fort, even though they felt that they were not being threatened by the Indians in this area. The fort in Cedar City was built before the agreement was reached to end the hostilities, more in preparation for what might take place. Due to the somewhat peaceful atmosphere in the southern end of the Territory, an all-out war between the settlers and the rem men never did occur. The Indians in the Cedar City area had remained relatively peaceful in spite of the skirmishes and incidents which took place during the Walker War.

John D. Lee took the place of Matthew Carruthers as Commander of the Military Affairs. General orders were given to finish the new fort and maintain vigilant military safeguards which greatly

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increased the labors and hardships of the settlers.¹ This new plot was organized into wards during the meeting on Sunday, August 21, 1853. The speakers were Patriarch E. H. Groves, Major John D. Lee, and President Henry Lunt. Ward One was south of first south Temple Street, Ward Two was west of first west Temple Street, Ward Three was north of first north Temple Street, and Ward Four was east of first east Temple Street. A piece of property 56 rods square in the center of town was known as the Temple Block (Block 13), and was also called the "Public Square." The Liberty Pole stood in the center of this block.²

Henry Lunt sent a letter to Salt Lake City which was published in the *Deseret News*, September 25, 1853, under the heading, "Items from Iron County." It read as follows:

I am glad to inform you that the Saints in this branch of the church are doing well as a general thing, and the spirit of the Lord is with us.

The general orders of the Governor are being carried out daily. The amount of labor that has been done since our removal from the Old Fort seems to surpass all I ever before saw. There is an immense quantity of hay stacked within our fort. We are now, nearly every man, engaged in enclosing the fort, principally with an adobe wall, and hope to have it finished soon. We have six men with the herd of cattle daily, well-armed, and a strong guard every night around the fort. As soon as the fort is enclosed, we hope to commence the Iron Works anew.

A tremendous flood came down Coal Creek on Saturday, Sept. 3, carrying away bridges, dams, and everything before it--brought an immense quantity of logs and rocks of immense size, and did some considerable damage to the Iron Works. The days have been warm of late and frosty nights. Pleasant rain today. Your brother in the cause of truth,

Henry Lunt

The flood that Henry referred to was the crowning blow for the Iron Works. It swept over the site, completely submerging the equipment and buildings, and carried away some of the property. Also, with the diversion dam washed out, there was no water for domestic use in the Fort.

The Walker War forced the suspension of working at the Iron Works while the colonists constructed fortifications and gathered the harvest of hay, grain, fuel and whatever other needs they might have to safely store for the winter. In addition to preparing against possible Indian attack, the settlers faced the gigantic task of rebuilding the dams and mending the breaches in the ditches and canals. There was little left to show for the eighteen thousand dollars that had been spent on the Iron Works during 1853.³

Elders Erastus Snow and Franklin D. Richards of the twelve apostles arrived in Cedar City on November 1, and brought Elder Isaac C. Haight with them to assist in the Iron Works. Governor Brigham Young was not ready to give up his dream of plentiful iron for the Great Basin. Haight brought his three wives and his children with him and, after only one month, was elected as the first mayor of Cedar City. He knew the Prophet Joseph Smith personally and was a member of the Nauvoo Legion, being among the forty men chosen to guard the Prophet while in Nauvoo. He was a native of New York, having been born in Windham County, May 27, 1813.⁴

A public meeting was held on Sunday, November 5, during which Elder Snow spoke at some length upon various subjects including the exodus of some of the members to California. He indicated that they would be losers by so doing and that it would be a blessing unto the Cedar residents if they were gone.⁵ He praised the saints for their good work in going ahead to build up this place so fast after the move from the old North Fort, and he expressed the necessity of building a meeting house and school house in the new fort. At that point in the sermon a motion was made to build a 25' by 41' meeting house with Bishop P. K. Smith and President Henry Lunt as the building committee. The motion carried.

An L.D.S. Iron County Stake Conference was held in Cedar City on November 20, 1853. There were 790 people residing in Cedar at

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that time. The following account was taken from the minutes of the meetings:

The first session was held at 11:00 a.m. and present of the Twelve were Elders Erastus Snow and Franklin D. Richards. The Presidency of the Stake was J. C. L. Smith, John Steele, and Henry Lunt. The conference was called to order by President Lunt. Congregation singing, and then the prayer was given by E. H. Groves. President Snow addressed the congregation.

During the 3:00 p.m. session President Smith presented the following brethren who have removed to California: Wm. Hewitt and wife, Richard Varley and wife, John Gregory, Thomas Machen, Wm. Couzens, Wm. Davies and wife, James Easton and two wives, John Grant, Wm. Henderson, Wm. Slack and wife, James Mitchell and wife, Matthew Easton, James Thorpe, Samuel Kershaw, Isaac Perry, Harvey C. Lad and wife, John Dart, Edward Davies and wife, David Davies, David Murie, and Sarah Wiley. It was moved and carried that they all be cut off from the Church. President Snow again spoke and remarked that something ought to be done relative to our stock and the propriety of establishing a herd ground at Summit Creek, that in case of an emergency communication could be immediately made with Parowan and this place, and the minute-mounted horsemen could fly to the rescue. This unanimously carried. Snow also said there were several brethren coming here as missionaries to the Indians, and the people should help them as much as possible.⁶

Erastus Snow encouraged the saints to do what is required of them without complaining and murmuring until the Fort was enclosed.⁷ There were two other meetings held on Monday. Much was said in regard to being missionaries to the Indians, teaching them,

trying to become acquainted with the Indian character and language and to establish schools for that purpose. Brother Snow felt that the settlers should help the Indian children learn the English language, teach them to work, and show them the benefits of it by paying them for their labor. Several men were appointed to help in this capacity.⁸

One of the settlers, John Spiers, wrote in his journal that he helped build the fort during the winter of 1853, and the brethren who guarded the town generally stood on the top of John D. Lee's two-story house, where they were much exposed to the inclemency of the weather. Some of them took sick owing to exposure to the cold.⁹

As there was a shortage of paper in the entire Territory, the *Deseret News* was hard pressed for printing paper. The paper they had, which was thick and gray, was manufactured in Salt Lake City. They put out the plea: "save your rags, everybody in Deseret, save your rags--old wagon covers, tents, quilts, shirts, etc. are wanted to make paper." Lunt, being the local agent for the *News* which was printed biweekly, wrote another article on Dec. 29, 1853, which appeared in the paper February 2, 1854. The article follows:

Editor of Deseret News . . . Dear Sir:

Feeling assured that a few lines from this part of the Territory would not be objectionable to the readers of your valuable paper, I will give you a few ideas of how we are situated.

The weather has been delightful till within two weeks, since which time we have had some snow and very cold nights, but again the smiles of pleasant sunshine are with us. This good weather has improved the completion date of our City wall which will be finished the present week. The festivities of Christmas are laid aside till this is done and the brethren seem united to see this work accomplished, with the gates hung. Then we shall feel men-like, having done our duty before indulging in merrymaking.

We have built an excellent school house, 60 feet by 25 feet, where we hold our meetings. It was

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dedicated on Christmas day, which day will long be remembered among us.

In the morning the Indians [Pihedes], to the amount of some 300, women and children included, gathered into the Fort. We preached to them in their own language and made them a donation of an ox, with some vegetables and flour. After, they went away rejoicing. Some of them were from the south and appeared very friendly, and a good spirit seemed among them towards us.

Schools are established for learning the Indian tongue and Brother Nephi Johnson is fulfilling his mission teaching the missionaries. Sunday, day and night schools are being started, that all classes may be instructed in useful branches that we may, one and all, be serviceable in rolling forth the great work. [Lunt was on the Examining Committee for the schools in the County, along with W. H. Dame and J. H. Martineau]. The Iron Works have stopped for the last few weeks to enclose the Fort, but have again commenced operations.

There is some snow and considerable ice in the canyon by which the coal operations are considerably retarded, but efforts are being made for a busy spring and summer that we may not be behind any settlement in the mountain for farming operations, and I assure you the Iron Works will be pushed forward with energy by its enterprising manager.

We have surveyed a new field of 1000 acres west of the present one. The brethren who have lately come in have not generally taken more than 10 or 5 acres. We are especially instructed to fence it with a good picket fence that our crops may be secure. Every man feels that he should be somebody in this community, that something be required of each to advance the Kingdom of our Father.

The Indians have not troubled us much--there were a few Pauvants here a week ago who had thieving propensities, but they have left and all is peace. We keep a good lookout for them. The military regulations are strict, and all seem determined to follow counsel that we may be saved thereby.

Respectfully, I remain your brother, Henry Lunt

John D. Lee wrote a letter to Brigham Young which was published in the February 16 edition of the *Deseret News*. The letter contained the following:

On Sunday before Christmas the people voted to enclose the City with walls, bars, and gates before they should dance and make merry, and from that time on a general rush was made until the gates were put up. This was accomplished on the 5th of January. The four wards which comprise the City had the privilege of the meeting house, two days each.

In the same letter Lee, who was closely associated with the Indians, described a conflict between the Navajos and the Pihedes. Quite a few Navajos assembled outside of the wall near Lee's house, while the Pihedes were inside the Fort. The Navajos shot a Pihede in the head, and the Pihedes were demanding the murderer. Lee wrote:

Brother Little and I stood on the Fort wall, we had the wall between us and, because the Pihedes had helped us build the wall, we had promised them protection within the Fort. The Pihedes were persuaded to forgive the Navajos, and all was peace.

January 24: On the 20th, a wind storm from the southwest blew down some 15 to 20 rods [about 300 feet] of our Fort Wall on the north and south lines.¹⁰

It was necessary to restore the damaged wall as soon as possible

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to provide the needed protection for the settlers. This required many hours of labor.

It was a City Ordinance that "No person or persons shall cut or make any hole or doorway through the wall of this Fort without making a door or shutter, bullet proof, and that must be with the advice and consent of the overseer."

1. George K. Bowering, "George K. Bowering Journal," 1853 Entry, S.U.U., p. 165, Special Collections Library, Cedar City, Utah.
2. Evelyn and York Jones, *Mayors of Cedar City*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Woodruff Printing Company, 1986), p. 20.
3. Karl Larson, *Erastus Snow*, "The Iron Works In Iron County."
4. Evelyn and York Jones, *op. cit.*, p. 10.
5. George K. Bowering, *op. cit.*, p. 168.
6. Andrew Jenson, *L.D.S. Journal History*, November 30, 1853, "James Whittaker Report."
7. Karl Larsen, *Erastus Snow*, "The Iron Works," p. 251.
8. *Ibid.*, p. 251.
9. William R. Palmer, "History File," Collection B-33, S.U.U. Special Collections Library, Cedar City, Utah.
10. *Deseret News*, February 16, 1854, Salt Lake City, Utah.

